Whose Contribution Counts?

Generative AI, Cultural Participation and Collective Authorship in Research-Creation

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Summary

I am an artistic practitioner and researcher working through research-creation. I am currently completing an MA in Interactive Arts and Technology after training in architecture and landscape architecture, and I create interactive 3D environments and multiplayer systems that examine how technical mediation shapes relations among participants. This project asks how GenAI systems, including models, interfaces and the platforms through which they are accessed, reorganize interpretive authority and collective authorship in collaborative artistic practice. Its subquestions ask how tools, defaults and facilitation privilege, flatten or misrecognize participants' culturally situated contributions; how collaborators negotiate uptake, refusal, credit and responsibility; and how artistic methods and a public artwork can make these hidden distributions of authority open to debate and revision. The stakes are cultural: platforms increasingly shape whose meanings become legible and who answers for shared work. The study begins with my own studio inquiry, then consultation with paid practitioners, three workshops for each of three cohorts of six to eight adult artists and community-engaged practitioners with participant observation, semi-structured focus groups, and a co-created room-scale installation proposed for exhibition at York. It aims to contribute a Communication & Culture account of how GenAI redistributes interpretive authority and a research-creation method for tracing participant-defined contributions, within the program's Technology in Practice and Media & Culture fields.

1 Introduction

GenAI systems increasingly mediate access to and participation in some forms of cultural production. Their training data, defaults, moderation rules, access conditions and contractual terms are

shaped largely by platform companies (Crawford, 2021). I therefore treat GenAI not as a neutral tool or autonomous artist, but as part of a cultural infrastructure that includes interfaces, institutions, facilitators and unequal conditions of access.

Three mechanisms give this infrastructure social stakes. The first is *platformized interpretive authority*. Richards (2025, 276) argues that the "safe and helpful" assistant functions "as a proxy for authority"; Caines found that subscription tiers, privacy conditions and opacity shaped what she and her students could make (Caines, 2026, 187–188, 194); and Caines and Watson describe a project whose outcome lay "completely in the hands of the corporations that designed the software" (Caines and Watson, 2023, 267). The second is *cultural legibility*: models may privilege, flatten, standardize, mistranslate, misrecognize or pass over culturally situated expression. South Asian participants found that text-to-image models reproduced an outsider's gaze on their cultures (Qadri et al., 2023), and AI writing suggestions moved Indian writers toward Western styles (Agarwal et al., 2025); each finding concerns particular models and tasks. The third is the gap between *technical provenance and social authorship*: a system can record who supplied what while collaborators credit someone else, and artists' work has entered training data without their consent (Jiang et al., 2023). Environmental cost, labour displacement and misinformation form the wider context (Caines, 2026, 182) but are not objects of this study.

Participation and authorship matter because they determine who takes part in meaning-making, whose contribution remains recognizable, who can revise or refuse a model's transformation, who receives public credit and who is held responsible when collaborative work circulates. They are where platform power becomes practical in everyday cultural production. One qualitative study cannot explain AI's effect on society, but situated research-creation can make these processes observable and yield analytically transferable concepts.

2 Objectives

2.1 Research problem and questions

Central question. How do GenAI systems reorganize interpretive authority and collective authorship in collaborative artistic practice?

SQ1. *Translation and cultural legibility.* How do selected models, interfaces, defaults, moderation systems and facilitation arrangements privilege, amplify, flatten, standardize, mistranslate, misrecognize, refuse or pass over participants' self-identified and culturally situated contributions? (Studio records; episodes; transformation histories; platform documentation.)

SQ2. *Negotiation and governance.* How do collaborators negotiate uptake, revision, refusal, attribution, credit, responsibility and collective decisions among contributors, the group, the artist-facilitator, models, platforms and institutions? (Field notes; group rules; version histories; focus groups.)

SQ3. *Research-creation and public form.* How can collaborative artistic methods and the form of a public artwork materialize otherwise hidden distributions of interpretive authority and leave them open to debate and revision? (Scores; versions of the work; studio journal.)

The exhibition is a creative, analytical and dissemination outcome. Because audience data will not be collected, the study will not make empirical claims about audience reception.

Provisional argument. GenAI does not merely add a nonhuman collaborator to collective artmaking; it may reorganize the conditions under which contributions become visible, legible, transformable, contestable, attributable, creditable, ownable and accountable. The research may confirm, complicate or reject this proposition, and it treats refusal, silence, failure, non-use, withdrawal, disagreement and unresolved parallel versions as meaningful outcomes.

Terms. *Participation* means taking part in consequential decisions, not merely receiving access to or interacting with a system. *Recognition* concerns whether a contribution remains perceptible and attributable within the shared work. *Interpretive authority* is the capacity to influence or decide what a contribution means, how it is transformed and what it becomes. *Attribution* or *credit* is the public acknowledgement of a contribution. *Authorship* is a socially and institutionally negotiated claim that a person or group substantively shaped the work. *Ownership* is a legal or contractual claim. *Responsibility* concerns who is expected to answer for the work and its consequences. *Technical provenance* is a system's record of inputs, transformations or versions: evidence, but not a definitive record of social authorship, cultural recognition or responsibility. *Culturally situated contributions* include languages, references, idioms, memories, aesthetic conventions, performance practices and forms of community knowledge that participants themselves identify as significant. The project will not judge cultural authenticity or treat anyone as representing a culture or community.

2.2 Theoretical perspective

Participation as power. Jenkins and colleagues describe participatory cultures as ones in which "members believe their contributions matter" (Jenkins et al., 2006, 3). Carpentier (2016) asks whether participants share power at the moments when decisions are made, which separates participation from access and interaction, and Bishop (2012) cautions that participatory art is too often judged by ethical rather than artistic criteria.

Mediation and infrastructure. Suchman (2007) shows that agency is figured and attributed in situated practice. AI-mediated communication research describes models that modify messages between people (Hancock et al., 2020), and the companies that run them present themselves as "platforms" while shaping the terms by which they are judged (Gillespie, 2010).

Collective production and recognition. Becker (1982) treats art as the work of a cooperative network organized by conventions that decide whose contribution counts as artistic. Hodson (2019, 32) shows that even when design is opened to others, "the story is still told in terms of design-led collaboration".

Research-creation and critical improvisation. Research-creation makes the making a way of knowing (Chapman and Sawchuk, 2012) and can challenge the norms of the fields it crosses (Loveless, 2019, 37, quoted in Caines and Watson, 2023, 255). Caines treats improvisation as a method built on "real-time decision-making with others, surprise, supported and accountable risk taking, deep listening, and … the reconfiguration of mistake" (Caines and Watson, 2023, 273; see also Caines, 2021), and reads her GenAI work as "a kind of critical improvisation practice" marked by "a constant cycle of navigating power, adaptation, surprise, failure, and creation" (Caines, 2026, 193). I ask how that cycle unfolds when the material is one another's offers.

2.3 Expected contribution and originality

The project's primary originality is conceptual: it moves beyond the binary question of whether a human or machine authored an output to examine how interpretive authority, recognition, credit and responsibility are distributed through interfaces, platform rules, facilitation and collective practice. Its methodological contribution is to trace participant-defined contribution trajectories across workshop episodes, reflective accounts, version histories and exhibition without treating technical provenance as a definitive record of authorship. Empirically, it would offer situated evidence of how collaborators negotiate transformations, defaults, refusal and credit; artistically, an installation and scores that keep revisions, absences and parallel versions perceptible; and practically, situated principles for consent, attribution and platform choice.

3 Methods and sources

3.1 Research methods

In the program's research-creation option, a substantial creative work and a 150–200-page dissertation together address the theoretical concerns (Joint Graduate Program in Communication & Culture, 2021). The five phases overlap and feed back into one another (Figure 1).

Phase 1: Studio inquiry. Before recruiting anyone, I will spend a sustained period investigating collaboration and GenAI through my own practice, working with three or four tool families for text, image, sound or spatial generation alongside non-AI procedures. I will examine each tool's defaults, moderation, access and privacy conditions, data custody and terms of service, keeping a reflexive journal, a decision log, an archive of failures and refusals, and a version record while making exploratory works and scores. This is artistic and critical inquiry rather than benchmarking. It ends by choosing no more than two generative modalities for the workshops; Unity remains the environment for spatial assembly, not the scholarly contribution.

Phase 2: Consultation. Before ethics-approved data collection, four to six paid practitioners will act as consultants to review draft scores and the proposed accessibility, consent, refusal, attribution and data-governance protocols. Their feedback will refine the research design but will not be analysed as study data. Any pilot involving data collection will occur only after ethics approval.

Phase 3: Collaborative workshops. About 18–24 adults will take part in three cohorts of six to eight. Participants will be recruited because their artistic or community-engaged practices involve language, place, memory, identity, cultural reference or community knowledge, not because they are expected to represent a demographic or cultural group. Open calls in Toronto and York Region, excluding anyone I teach, will seek variation in discipline, cultural and linguistic experience, and familiarity with GenAI. Cohorts of this size can negotiate collectively and still be observed closely; the scale rests on information power (Malterud et al., 2016), not saturation (Braun and Clarke, 2021), and on available honoraria, venue capacity and analysis time. Each cohort attends three sequential workshops of about two and a half hours, plus a focus group, with make-up sessions: the first sets conventions and makes work without assuming AI is needed; the second works through improvisational scores with the selected modalities and AI/non-AI combinations; the third develops material for the installation. Cohorts negotiate how contributions may be transformed, whether GenAI must be used, what may be shown or removed, how credit is assigned and how disagreement is preserved. Participants may accept, revise, reject, fork or withhold a transformation, and may refuse GenAI at any point without losing standing in the collaboration, retaining negotiated authority over use, re-

vision, attribution, exhibition and withdrawal. Through disclosed participant observation, my field notes will record when I make art, facilitate, observe or analyse.

Phase 4: Focus groups. Each cohort joins one semi-structured focus group of 60–90 minutes on recognition, authorship, cultural legibility, refusal, responsibility, platform authority and data governance. Group interaction is part of the data (Kitzinger, 1994), but confidentiality cannot be guaranteed in a group, as participants will be told. Participants reflect without authoring the findings, so this is not co-analysis; private follow-up conversations are offered.

Phase 5: Collaborative installation. The provisional form is a room-scale, multichannel interactive installation assembled in Unity. The installation will not merely visualize workshop records. Its spatial, temporal, visual and sonic composition will operate as a second site of inquiry: incompatible versions may coexist, refusals may interrupt the work, and contributions may remain present without being absorbed into a single polished output. Through this form, authorship appears as negotiated and unresolved rather than as a settled list of inputs. Scores act as propositions that participants test, failures reveal infrastructural assumptions, revisions redistribute decision-making and visible absences record refusal. Each cohort keeps an autonomous module with its own credit and data rules and transformation history; only the shared spatial structure is negotiated across cohorts. The preferred venue is the first-floor Art Gallery at York's Markham Campus (York University Markham Campus, 2024), but it remains a proposal requiring institutional approval and resources, and another York or partner venue may be used. Consent to exhibit is separate from consent to research, no audience data will be collected without a separately approved protocol, and the work will be documented for examination and dissemination.

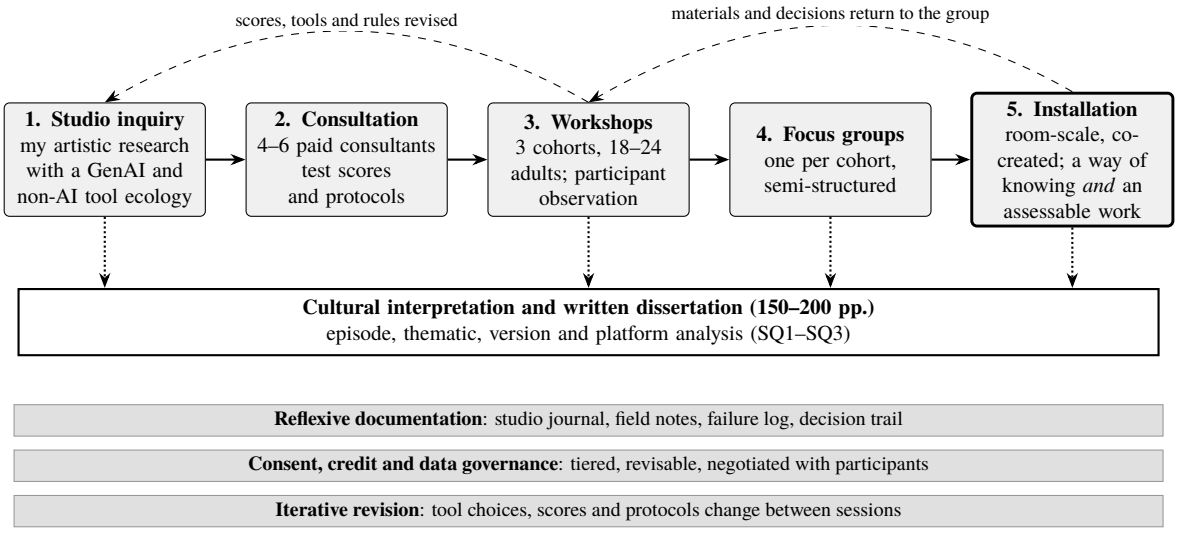


Figure 1: Proposed research-creation design. Solid arrows show the sequence of phases, dashed arrows feedback, and dotted arrows evidence moving into interpretation; grey bands run across every phase.

Analysis is aligned with the subquestions. For SQ1, I will analyse selected workshop episodes multimodally, adapting the video microethnography McArthur (2015) used for interface interaction, and read interfaces, terms of service and model documentation as cultural documents. For SQ2, reflexive thematic analysis of the focus groups (Braun and Clarke, 2019) is read alongside field notes, episodes and group-created rules. For SQ3, version analysis charts each state of the work against the contributors who shaped it, after the version timelines of Hodson (2019, 10). A system log records events, inputs and transformations; it does not independently establish intention, authorship, recognition or responsibility. Contribution trajectories will therefore be interpreted through participant accounts, negotiated attribution, contextual observation, material versions and acknowledged uncertainty, not used as a surveillance record. Discrepant cases, including refusal and non-use, reflexive memos and a decision trail keep the interpretation accountable. Because models cannot be isolated from facilitation, platform, group history or changing tool versions, claims will be situated and analytically transferable rather than causal.

Consent will be tiered and revisable (Strengers et al., 2021), given separately for recording, model input, research analysis, exhibition, documentation and reuse. Every activity has a manual route, and participants may decline particular forms of visibility. No identifiable voice, image or text, and no culturally sensitive material, will be sent to a model without specific consent. Participants will be told that commercial services may retain or reuse prompts and outputs, and I will prefer local or institutionally approved tools where feasible. Groups will agree in advance how withdrawal works once material has been remixed: identifiable contributions are removed where feasible, but a remixed contribution cannot always be fully separated from exhibited work. Legal ownership, contractual terms, public credit, felt authorship, research authorship and responsibility are treated as distinct. Data will be minimized, stored securely with restricted access, and retained and deleted on a documented schedule. Participants and consultants will receive honoraria and access costs; if funding is inadequate, I will reduce the sample or the number of sessions rather than rely on unpaid artistic labour. Alternatives to sound-only or vision-only interaction, and help at every level of AI literacy, support different forms of participation. Participants will not be asked to disclose or perform trauma, to represent a community, or to educate me about cultural misrecognition. Participation alone does not make the process equitable (Birhane et al., 2022).

3.2 Sources

Primary sources are generated in the five phases, with interface documentation and terms of service; secondary sources appear in Section 4.

3.3 Anticipated problems of access

If a cohort cannot finish, its completed sessions remain usable as a smaller case; if the gallery is unavailable, the work will be shown elsewhere or as a documented installation; and if platforms close, change terms or update models, Phase 1 keeps substitutes, including a local model.

Expandable case-study architecture. After the initial studio inquiry, one bounded case-study strand may be co-developed with Dr. Caines around the most appropriate case from her current research, subject to her guidance and any partner approvals. Her work on improvisation, playtesting and socially responsive creative technologies offers several possible connections, but no particular project relationship is assumed at this stage; her SSHRC project *Interfacing, Playtesting, Resetting* (Goodfellow Craig, 2026), for example, may offer a possible context, subject to Dr. Caines's guidance and partner approval. Any integration would extend, rather than determine, the core research questions and would require separate agreement concerning roles, access, community or partner governance, consent, data, ethics, resources, credit and outputs. The doctoral study remains complete without any one external case study.

4 Relationship to existing literature and professional practice

Architecture at Tabriz Islamic Art University and landscape architecture at Istanbul Technical University taught me to treat designed environments as media of social life; in ITU's Virtual Landscape Lab I studied how people perceive mediated environments (Jahandideh et al., 2023). My MA research in Steve DiPaola's iViz Lab at Simon Fraser University asked what happens when a technical system translates an ambiguous human state into a representation shared with others. In a three-player networked Unity game, each role carried an animated halo integrating heart rate and heart-rate variability, offered as a trace to interpret rather than a verdict (Jahandideh et al., 2026). Teams supported a struggling teammate faster than with no cue, and matched an explicit numeric display at lower workload and invasiveness, although players rated the numbers more trustworthy and useful. Participants accepted this visibility only when it was optional, mutable and subtle, with control over who could see it as a precondition, and the paper argues for a right to be illegible. In *BioTerrarium*, physiology shaped fog, vegetation, light and visual clarity in place of a meter, an approach I called ambient reciprocity (Jahandideh, 2026). In both, representation shaped what others perceived and trusted, when they intervened and what control people demanded over their visibility.

The PhD asks what happens when models and platforms translate participants' words, images, sounds, gestures or cultural references into collective artistic material. Neither MA study examined GenAI, collective authorship or cultural production directly. They provide the conceptual problem

of mediated interpretation and the preparation, in Unity, C#, networking, real-time data, research ethics and mixed-methods studies, from which the doctoral project develops toward artistic inquiry, participant observation and platform analysis. As artist, developer, facilitator, observer, analyst and curator, I will document how these roles shape what participants can do.

Four artistic practices inspire the project's questions, and each changes a specific decision in its design. Anna Ridler's *Myriad (Tulips)* exhibits thousands of tulip photographs she labelled by hand, making a dataset's labour and classification into the artwork (Ridler, 2018); it leads me to keep prompts, labels and rejected outputs as exhibitable material. Stephanie Dinkins's *Not the Only One* is trained on oral histories from three generations of women in her family and hosted locally to protect community data (Dinkins, 2018); it makes data custody a criterion for choosing tools. Holly Herndon and Mat Dryhurst's *The Call* trained choral models on recordings of fifteen community choirs and tested a data trust (Herndon and Dryhurst, 2024); because its governance was designed by the artists and institution, my workshops instead ask participants to set credit and data rules. Sougwen Chung's *Drawing Operations* pairs her drawing with robotic systems trained on her own drawings and gestures (Chung, 2014), a model of improvised co-performance that my scores extend to many contributors. Caines's *multiPLAY*, with workshops, open studios and an artist hackathon for Canadian improvisers (Caines, 2019), and *ImprovEnabled*, a strengths-based improvisation project developed with community partners (Caines and Stewart, 2015), are methodological precedents for community-engaged improvisation, supported risk, listening and accessible workshop design; they are not research sites for this study.

The project is situated primarily within Technology in Practice because it critically examines how GenAI platforms, interfaces and institutions configure cultural practice. It is situated secondarily within Media & Culture because it studies cultural production, representation, participation, authorship and labour. Its object is mediation, participation and power rather than a model's technical performance: it treats platforms as cultural infrastructures, draws on critical theory, and uses creative practice as a method of inquiry whose installation is implicated in the dissertation's argument (Joint Graduate Program in Communication & Culture, 2021). Dr. Caines's work on critical improvisation and GenAI is its closest scholarly ground; her GenAI study focused mostly on course and workshop design (Caines, 2026, 176), whereas this project follows how collaborators negotiate one another's contributions in sustained art-making and exhibition.

5 Proposed chapter outline

1. GenAI and cultural participation.
2. Participation, mediation and collective production.

3. Methodology: research-creation and reflexivity.
4. The studio inquiry and the tool ecology as cultural document.
5. Translation, recognition and refusal in the workshops.
6. Credit, responsibility and the public artwork.
7. Protocols and wider stakes.

6 Proposed timeline

Full-time from Fall 2027; 2027–2028 covers coursework, comprehensive examinations, literature review and the start of studio inquiry.

Jan–Apr 2029	Proposal approval; ethics application; Phase 1 studio inquiry continues.
May–Aug 2029	Phase 2 consultation.
Sep 2029–Apr 2030	Phase 3 workshops with three cohorts; Phase 4 focus groups.
May–Dec 2030	Phase 5 co-creation and proposed exhibition; analysis.
Jan–Jun 2031	Writing and revision of chapters.
Jul–Aug 2031	Submission and defence (Year 5 in reserve).

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